

Spain Itinerary – Aug 27 to Sep 11, 2026

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! Important

Before you leave: register for the Camino Frances / Pilgrim Pass at cms-pilgrim-pass.web.app/preregistration to get the QR code required for check-in at Roncesvalles (and other participating albergues along the Way).

Itinerary

Day 1 – Thu Aug 27

- Drive Grand Rapids → Todd’s house, 5739 S Franklin Ave, La Grange Highlands, IL (~2h45m–3h15m); leave car there.
- Uber Todd’s house → ORD (~20–25 min).
- Chicago ORD → Madrid (Iberia IB 342, Business, dep 4:55 pm, arr Aug 28 8:20 am)

Day 2 – Fri Aug 28

- 08:20 — Land Madrid Barajas T4.
- 08:20–08:50 — Passport control (Schengen entry) + baggage claim.
- ~08:55 — Cercanías **C1** from the “Aeropuerto T4” station → Atocha (~30 min, €2.60) — buy at the machines or with contactless card.
- ~09:30 — Arrive Atocha; head to the Puerta de Atocha long-distance side and clear security/bag X-ray (required for AVE/ALVIA departures).
- 10:32 — Depart Madrid–Puerta de Atocha (ALVIA, Localizador **YNPLW2**) → Pamplona/Iruña. (~1h40m buffer from landing — comfortable even with a slow passport line.)
- Transfer Pamplona → Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port (taxi/bus — see Trip References for Taxi Asier contact).
- Check-in: **Gîte de la Porte Saint Jacques** (Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port).
- Pick up pilgrim credential in SJPP if not already obtained.

Note

Notes — Aug 28

Day 3 – Sat Aug 29 (Camino Day 1)

- **Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port → Roncesvalles** (~25 km / 15.5 mi) — the Napoleon Route over the Pyrenees.
 - Route highlights: steep climb out of SJPP past Refuge Orisson; the Virgin of Biakorri statue; the high ridge crossing the France–Spain border with sweeping Pyrenees views; descent through beech forest at Col de Lepoeder into Roncesvalles’ Collegiate Church and monastery.
- Show QR code / passport at check-in. Albergue closes at 22:00; reservation held until 19:00 unless later arrival is flagged.
- Dinner seating 20:30.

- Overnight: **Albergue de Peregrinos de Orreaga-Roncesvalles** (Localizador **AL08344890**).

Caution

This is the hardest and most exposed day of the entire Camino (~1,200 m climb, few bailout points), done one day after a transatlantic flight and jet lag. Start at first light. Check weather the night before — in fog, high wind, or rain, take the lower **Valcarlos route** instead (~19 km, road-based, far less exposure); ask at the SJPP pilgrim office. Carry rain layer, poles, and food/water since services on the Napoleon route are minimal.

Days 4–14 – Aug 30 to Sep 9 (Camino Francés – Roncesvalles to Burgos)

- **Day 4 (Aug 30):** Roncesvalles → Zubiri (~21.5 km / 13.4 mi)
 - Route highlights: descent through Auritz/Burguete (the village where Hemingway stayed and wrote of trout fishing in *The Sun Also Rises*); Roncesvalles pass and Erro valley beech forest; Alto de Erro; drop into Zubiri over the medieval Puente de la Rabia.
- **Day 5 (Aug 31):** Zubiri → Pamplona (~20.4 km / 12.7 mi)
 - Route highlights: riverside path along the Río Arga; Larrasoana; the Romanesque Trinidad de Arre bridge marking the entry into greater Pamplona; Pamplona's old town, Plaza del Castillo, and the Gothic cathedral.
- **Day 6 (Sep 1):** Pamplona → Puente la Reina (~23.8 km / 14.8 mi)
 - Route highlights: Alto del Perdón ridge — wind turbines and the famous silhouette-of-pilgrims sculpture with panoramic views over Navarra; Uterga and Muruzábal; Puente la Reina's iconic 11th-century Romanesque bridge, where the Camino Francés and Camino Aragonés merge.
- **Day 7 (Sep 2):** Puente la Reina → Estella (~21.5 km / 13.4 mi)
 - Route highlights: hilltop medieval village of Cirauqui with a stretch of original Roman road below it; Lorca and Villatuerta; Estella/Lizarra's Palacio de los Reyes de Navarra and the church of San Pedro de la Rúa.
- **Day 8 (Sep 3):** Estella → Los Arcos (~21.3 km / 13.2 mi)
 - Route highlights: Bodegas Irache's free pilgrim wine fountain (Fuente del Vino) right on the trail; Monasterio de Irache; Villamayor de Monjardín beneath its hilltop castle ruins; Los Arcos and the ornate church of Santa María.

- **Day 9 (Sep 4):** Los Arcos → Logroño (~27.5 km / 17.1 mi) — long and largely shadeless through vineyard country; start at dawn.
 - Route highlights: Sansol and Torres del Río’s octagonal, Templar-linked Church of the Holy Sepulchre; crossing from Navarra into La Rioja; Viana’s old town; entering Logroño — Rioja’s wine capital — over the Puente de Piedra and into the Calle Laurel tapas district.
- **Day 10 (Sep 5):** Logroño → Nájera (~29 km / 18.0 mi) — longest stage of the trip, same exposed terrain; start at dawn, carry extra water.
 - Route highlights: Parque de la Grajera reservoir just outside Logroño; Navarrete’s vineyards and pottery tradition; Nájera’s cliffside setting above the Río Najerilla and the royal pantheon in the Monasterio de Santa María la Real.
- **Day 11 (Sep 6):** Nájera → Santo Domingo de la Calzada (~21 km / 13.0 mi)
 - Route highlights: Azofra and Cirueña; Santo Domingo de la Calzada’s cathedral, famous for keeping a live rooster and hen inside in honor of the town’s “hanged pilgrim” legend.
- **Day 12 (Sep 7):** Santo Domingo de la Calzada → Belorado (~22.8 km / 14.2 mi)
 - Route highlights: hilltop Grañón with views back over the Rioja plain; crossing from La Rioja into Castilla y León near Redecilla del Camino; Vitoria de Rioja, birthplace of Santo Domingo; Belorado’s old quarter and nearby cave dwellings.
- **Day 13 (Sep 8):** Belorado → San Juan de Ortega (~23.7 km / 14.7 mi)
 - Route highlights: Villafranca Montes de Oca, the last village before a long climb into the Montes de Oca oak and pine forest (historically the most dangerous stretch of the Camino for robbers); the remote Romanesque monastery at San Juan de Ortega, known for a twice-yearly light phenomenon illuminating a capital inside the church at the equinoxes.
- **Day 14 (Sep 9):** San Juan de Ortega → Burgos (~25.8 km / 16.0 mi)
 - Route highlights: Agés and Atapuerca, site of a UNESCO World Heritage archaeological complex with some of the oldest hominid fossils in Europe; the terrain opens into flatter farmland on the approach to Burgos (a preview of the Meseta beyond); Burgos’s Gothic cathedral — a UNESCO World Heritage Site — and El Cid’s tomb in the old town.

Day 15 – Thu Sep 10

- Burgos → Madrid (train/bus, ~2.5–3 hrs — book once travel day is confirmed).
- Overnight near Madrid (airport-side, ahead of the 11:45 am flight).

Day 16 – Fri Sep 11

- Madrid → Chicago ORD (Iberia IB 341, Business, dep 11:45 am, arr 2:25 pm).
 - Uber ORD → Todd's house, La Grange Highlands, IL (~20–25 min); pick up car, drive Grand Rapids (~2h45m–3h15m).
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Packing List

Documents & Money

- Passport
- Pilgrim credential (credencial) — get stamped daily
- Credit + ATM cards

Pack Setup

- Backpack with rain cover (35–40L)
- 1 small dry sack (electronics/passport)
- Packing cubes + plastic bags (organization, laundry separation)

Clothing

- 2 quick-dry short-sleeve tees
- 1 long-sleeve thermal / light layer (cool mornings crossing the Pyrenees on Day 1)
- 1 light fleece or packable insulated layer
- 1 lightweight rain jacket
- 1 convertible hiking pant
- 1 pair town/casual pants or shorts
- 3 pairs quick-dry underwear
- 3 pairs hiking socks (merino blend)

Footwear

- Trail runners or light hiking shoes (broken in well before the trip)
- Lightweight sandals or flip-flops (evenings)

Toiletries

- Toothbrush + travel toothpaste
- Small liquid soap (body + laundry, e.g. Dr. Bronner's)
- Travel deodorant
- Quick-dry towel
- Sunscreen (August sun is strong, especially crossing the Meseta near Burgos)
- Lip balm with SPF

Health & First Aid

- Blister pads (Compeed-style hydrocolloid) — essential for Day 1's Pyrenees crossing
- Ibuprofen / acetaminophen / personal medications
- Hand sanitizer, tissues
- Earplugs + eye mask (shared albergue dorms)
- Trekking poles (recommended for the SJPP–Roncesvalles descent)

Electronics

- iPhone + USB-C cord
- EU plug adapter
- AirPods
- Portable power bank

Other

- Sunglasses
- Sun hat
- Sleep sack / liner (albergue bedding varies)
- 2 × 1L water bottles (heat + climb on Day 1 demand real hydration capacity)
- Pen (credencial stamps, customs form on the flight home)

Trip References (Bookings & Contacts)

Flights

- **Aug 27 — ORD → MAD (Iberia IB 342, Business)** — dep 4:55 pm Aug 27, arr 8:20 am Aug 28.

- **Sep 11 — MAD → ORD (Iberia IB 341, Business) — dep 11:45 am, arr 2:25 pm.**

Trains

- **Aug 28 — Madrid Puerta de Atocha → Pamplona/Iruña (ALVIA) — dep 10:32 am.**
 - Localizador: **YNPLW2** | Importe: €81.65 | 1 billete

Ground Transport

- **Grand Rapids → ORD (Aug 27 – Sep 11)**
 - Drive to Todd's house — 5739 S Franklin Ave, La Grange Highlands, IL — and leave the car there for the trip.
 - Uber Todd's ORD on both ends (~20–25 min each way).
- **Pamplona → Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port**
 - Taxi de confianza Roncesvalles / Taxi Asier: info@taxiasier.com / +34 670 61 61 90 / www.taxiasier.com (also covers SJPP Roncesvalles airport/train station, 9-seater)

Lodging

- **Aug 28 — Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port: Gîte de la Porte Saint Jacques**
 - Address: 51 rue de la Citadelle, Saint-Jean-Pied-de-Port, France 64220
 - Check-in Fri Aug 28 → Check-out Sat Aug 29
 - Booking.com reservation #**6828058341** | €49 paid
- **Aug 29 — Roncesvalles: Albergue de Peregrinos de Orreaga-Roncesvalles**
 - Address: Carretera N-135, s/n, Roncesvalles, Navarra 31650
 - Phone: +34 948 760 000 | info@alberguederoncesvalles.com | www.alberguederoncesvalles.com
 - Localizador: **AL08344890** | €35 (alojamiento, cena y desayuno)
 - Dinner seating 20:30. Doors close 22:00. Reservation held until 19:00 unless late arrival is flagged.
 - Passport/ID required at check-in for every guest on the reservation.
 - Pilgrim Pass QR code required — register in advance: cms-pilgrim-pass.web.app/pre-registration

To Be Booked

- Lodging for Aug 30 – Sep 9 (Camino stages, Zubiri through Burgos) — book a day or two ahead given peak August demand.
- Burgos → Madrid transport for Sep 10.
- Madrid lodging for the night of Sep 10.